ZAKHEERA AI SOLUTIONS (PRIVATE) LIMITED

Grievance and Escalation Procedure

Complaints, harassment inquiries and whistleblowing

Policy ID	ZAI-HR-GR-009
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Policy owner	Human Resources and Legal
Applies to	All employees, interns and contractors
Approved by	Chief Executive Officer and Head of Human Resources
HR contact	hr@zakheera.ai | Extension 2200 | HR Helpdesk on the ZakheeraHR portal

1. Purpose and Commitments

ZAKHEERA wants employees to raise concerns early and safely. This procedure explains how to raise a workplace grievance, what happens next, how serious complaints (harassment, discrimination, misconduct) are handled, and how the Company protects those who speak up.

- Every complaint is taken seriously, heard fairly and handled confidentially to the extent possible.
- Retaliation against anyone who raises a concern in good faith, or who helps in an investigation, is strictly prohibited and is a dismissal offence.
- Employees are not required to go to their direct manager if the complaint is about the manager.
- False complaints made knowingly in bad faith may lead to disciplinary action.

2. What Counts as a Grievance

A grievance is any work-related concern, for example unfair treatment, unclear or unequal application of policy, workload, working conditions, pay or benefits errors, performance rating concerns (see the appeal route in the Performance Review Policy), interpersonal conflict, bullying, or manager behaviour.

3. Four-Level Escalation Path

Level	Who	What happens	Time limit
1. Informal	Direct manager (or skip-level manager if the manager is involved)	Discuss the issue and try to resolve it. A written summary is kept if the employee requests	Resolve within 5 working days
2. HR Business Partner	HRBP for your department	Submit a written grievance on ZakheeraHR (Helpdesk, then Grievance) or by email to hr@zakheera.ai. HRBP meets both sides and proposes a resolution	Response in 3 working days, resolution within 10 working days
3. Grievance Committee	Head of HR plus two members (a Department Head from another team and an employee representative nominated by staff)	Formal hearing, evidence review, written decision	Hearing within 7 working days of escalation, decision within 15 working days

Level	Who	What happens	Time limit
4. Appeal to the CEO	Chief Executive Officer	Reviews the process and decision. The decision of the CEO is final within the Company	Appeal within 10 working days of the committee decision, CEO decision within 15 working days

Employees may skip Level 1 for serious matters. They may bring a colleague as support to formal meetings, but not external lawyers, unless required by law.

4. Harassment and Discrimination Complaints

ZAKHEERA complies with the Protection Against Harassment of Women at the Workplace Act 2010 and applies the same standards of dignity to all employees regardless of gender. A Code of Conduct on harassment is displayed in every office.

- Harassment includes unwelcome sexual advances, requests for favours, comments, gestures, images, messages or any conduct that creates an intimidating, hostile or offensive environment, as well as discrimination based on gender, religion, ethnicity, language, disability or marital status.
- Complaints can be made in writing or verbally to any member of the Inquiry Committee, the Head of HR, or via the confidential line harassment@zakheera.ai. No manager approval is needed.
- The standing Inquiry Committee has 3 members, including at least one woman and one senior manager. A committee member with a conflict of interest steps aside.
- The Committee serves a copy of the complaint to the accused within 3 working days, who has 7 days to respond in writing.
- The inquiry is completed within 30 days of the complaint, as per law. The Committee gives a written report and recommendations to the CEO within 10 days of finishing.
- Interim protection, such as separate seating, a change of reporting line or paid leave, may be arranged during the inquiry.
- Penalties range from a warning, demotion or withholding of increments to termination, and may include a fine. A complainant who is unhappy with the decision may appeal to the Provincial Ombudsman within 30 days, as per law, and may also go to court.

5. Whistleblowing and Ethics Concerns

Concerns about fraud, bribery, data breaches, safety hazards, financial misreporting or legal violations can be raised confidentially at ethics@zakheera.ai or through the anonymous ethics form on ZakheeraHR. Reports go to the Head of Internal Audit and Head of HR. Anonymous reports are reviewed, and the identity of named reporters is protected. Retaliation is prohibited.

6. Investigation Standards

- Investigators must be impartial and not involved in the matter.
- Both sides are heard and given a chance to present evidence and witnesses.
- Records are confidential and stored by HR for at least 6 years.
- Outcomes are shared with the parties in writing. Details are limited to those who need to know.

7. Emergency Contacts for Urgent Concerns

Concern	Contact
General grievance	hr@zakheera.ai, Extension 2200
Harassment or discrimination	harassment@zakheera.ai (Inquiry Committee)
Fraud, ethics, whistleblowing	ethics@zakheera.ai (confidential)
Safety hazard or accident	admin@zakheera.ai, Extension 2400
Immediate danger	Call 15 (police) or 1122 (rescue) and then inform Admin and HR

8. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Who do I contact if my manager is the problem?
A: Go straight to your HR Business Partner or hr@zakheera.ai. You do not have to start with your manager.

Q: How long does a harassment inquiry take?
A: The Inquiry Committee must complete it within 30 days of the complaint.

Q: Can I complain anonymously?
A: Ethics and whistleblowing concerns can be submitted anonymously through ethics@zakheera.ai or the form on ZakheeraHR. Harassment complaints are best made by name so the Committee can protect and support you, but a confidential line is available.

Q: What if I am unhappy with the HR decision?
A: Escalate to the Grievance Committee (Level 3) and then appeal to the CEO within 10 working days.

Q: Will I be punished for complaining?
A: No. Retaliation is prohibited and is a dismissal offence.

Q: Can I bring someone with me to a hearing?
A: Yes, a colleague as support. External lawyers are not allowed unless the law requires it.

Q: Where can I appeal a harassment decision?
A: To the Provincial Ombudsman within 30 days of the decision, as per law.